

Supporting Details - Study Guide

Learn how to tell the difference between a detail that actually proves an idea and a detail that is merely related.

The core question

If the author makes a point, which sentence or detail gives the strongest direct support for that point?

1. What counts as supporting evidence?

Strong support directly helps prove or explain the idea in the question.

Related information may be about the same topic but does not actually prove the idea.

Background information gives context but may not support the specific claim being tested.

Detail type	What it does	Example
Direct support	Provides evidence for the exact idea	Attendance rose 18% after evening hours were added.
Related detail	Shares the topic but proves something else	The library opened in 1986.
Background	Explains context without proving the point	The library serves three neighborhoods.

2. How exam-style questions usually ask it

Direct: Which detail best supports the idea that ___?

Strongest evidence: Which sentence provides the strongest support for ___?

Evidence check: Which detail from the passage most clearly shows that ___?

The wording changes, but the job is the same: match the idea in the question to the most direct evidence in the text.

3. A four-step method

1. Restate the idea. Put the claim in your own words before looking at the options.

2. Predict the kind of evidence you need. Ask what would actually prove or explain that claim.

3. Compare each option to the exact idea. A true sentence is not automatically good evidence.

4. Choose the most direct support. Prefer evidence that requires the least extra assumption.

4. The most common traps

Mentioned, but not supportive. The detail appears in the passage, so it feels safe, but it does not prove the idea.

Weak indirect support. The detail points in the right direction but another option is more direct.

Evidence for a different point. The sentence is important, but it supports another idea from the passage.

Contradictory detail. The option actually weakens the idea in the question.

5. Worked example

Idea to support

The school garden project increased student participation outside regular class time.

Detail A: The garden includes herbs, tomatoes, and native flowers.

Detail B: More than 60 students volunteered for weekend planting sessions during the first month.

Detail C: The garden is located behind the science building.

Best evidence: B. It directly shows students taking part outside normal class time. A and C are true details, but neither proves participation increased.

6. Strength of evidence

When two choices seem possible, ask which one is more specific, more direct, and more clearly connected to the idea. The strongest answer usually leaves less work for you to do.

7. Quick checklist

Before selecting an answer, check:

- Does this detail address the exact idea in the question?
- Is it evidence, not just background?
- Does it support this idea rather than a different one?

- Is another option more direct?

8. Mini practice

A town installed shaded bus shelters at six heavily used stops. Before the change, riders often waited in direct sun during summer afternoons. A survey taken two months later found that riders at the upgraded stops were more likely to rate the wait as comfortable, even though bus arrival times had not changed.

Idea: The shelters improved riders' experience without changing the bus schedule.

Which detail best supports the idea?

- A. The town upgraded six stops.
- B. Riders had previously waited in direct sun.
- C. Riders rated the wait as more comfortable even though arrival times stayed the same.
- D. The survey was taken two months after the change.

Answer: C. It directly connects the new shelters to greater comfort while also confirming that the schedule itself did not change.

Remember

The best supporting detail is not simply true. It is the detail that most directly helps prove the exact idea being tested.